

A Book for Boys and Girls

Or, Country Rhimes for Children

JOHN BUNYAN

NORTH PASS PRESS

2026

A Book for Boys and Girls
First Edition

Published by North Pass Press, 2026
<https://northpass.press>

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Printed in the United States of America.

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Publisher's Note

John Bunyan's *A Book for Boys and Girls*—later popularized under the title *Divine Emblems*—was first published in 1686, just two years before the author's death. By the 1680s, Bunyan had become a widely respected preacher and author in England. Despite being a nonconformist who had spent twelve years in prison for his beliefs, his popularity across England was so immense that many referred to him as "Bishop Bunyan," as his arbitration in disputes outside his own church was frequently sought and respected. When he died in 1688, he was laid to rest in Bunhill Fields, the famous London burial ground for religious dissenters, where his grave now stands near that of Daniel Defoe.

This work was born out of an exasperated attempt to rouse a society Bunyan felt was growing increasingly immersed in frivolity and indifference to the things of God. He wanted to present divine truth in a way that would leave a lasting impression on the culture. Despite frequently being marketed as a book for children, Bunyan explicitly states that his intention went far beyond the young. Writing that his 'very beard [he] cast behind the bush,' he proclaimed his determination to meet the men and women of his day exactly where they stood. He deliberately adopted a simple, childlike style because he regarded many adults of his day as little more than

“artificial babes.” Yet, while executing this sharp critique, Bunyan did not forget the actual children. He prefixed his work with an early English alphabet and a reading guide titled “An Help to Children to Read English,” designed as a foundational educational tool.

For over three centuries, however, the true scope of Bunyan’s vision was lost to history. Every printed edition of this work since the 17th century has been based on abridged or heavily edited versions. These versions systematically cut out significant portions of Bunyan’s original poetry and stripped away his unique pedagogical addendum. Literary historians and past editors—including George Offor—were forced to publish incomplete editions because, despite searching high and low throughout England and America, they simply could not find a copy of the original 1686 text. In fact, it was not until the end of the 19th century that the sole remaining copy of the original edition was acquired by the British Museum.

To our knowledge, this North Pass Press edition may represent the very first newly typeset edition of the original text printed since 1686. It fully restores Bunyan’s unaltered poetry, recovers his original intent, and faithfully preserves his original educational guide in the Appendix. To this, we have added “A Caution to Stir Up to Watch Against Sin,” which is a poem that George Offor believed was crucial for all, but especially the young.

In an era saturated with short attention spans and curated media, *A Book for Boys and Girls* serves as a brilliant historical reminder of the power of creative com-

munication. When Bunyan looked at a society he felt was losing its way, he didn't give up; he changed his strategy. He used simple rhymes, everyday language, and accessible metaphors to impress profound truth upon the minds of regular people.

May reading his work not only bring you joy but also inspire you to continue trying to share important truths with the world around you. For, as Bunyan himself reminds us, "Great things, by little ones, are made to shine."

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To the Reader

Courteous Reader,
The title-page will shew, if there thou look,
Who are the proper subjects of this book.
They're boys and girls of all sorts and degrees,
From those of age, to children on the knees.
Thus comprehensive am I in my notions;
They tempt me to it by their childish motions.
We now have boys with beards, and girls that be
Big as old women, wanting gravity.

Then do not blame me, 'cause I thus describe them;
Flatter I may not, lest thereby I bribe them
To have a better judgment of themselves,
Then wise men have of babies on their shelves.
Their antick tricks, fantastick modes, and way,
Shew they like very boys and girls, do play
With all the frantick fopp'ries of this age;
And that in open view, as on a stage;
Our *bearded* men, do act like *beardless* boys;
Our women please themselves with childish toys.

Our ministers, long time by word and pen,
Deal with them, counting them, not boys but men:
Thunder-bolts they shot at them, and their toys:

But hit then not, 'cause they were girls and boys.
The better charge, the wider still they shot,
Or else so high, these dwarfs they touched not.
Instead of men, they found them girls and boys,
Addict to nothing as to childish toys.

Wherefore good Reader, that I save them may,
I now with them, the very *dottril* play.¹
And since at gravity they make a tush,
My very beard I cast behind the bush.
And like a fool stand fing'ring of their toys;
And all to shew them, they are girls and boys.

Nor do I blush, although I think some may
Call me a baby, 'cause I with them play:
I do't to shew them how each *fingle-fangle*,
On which they doting are, their souls entangle,
As with a web, a trap, a ginn, a snare:
And will destroy them, have they not a care.

Paul seem'd to play the fool, that he might gain
Those that were fools indeed, if not in grain.
And did it by their things, that they might know
Their emptiness, and might be brought unto
What would them save from sin and vanity.
A noble act, and full of honesty.

¹Dottril: A term used for those who imitate or are easily fooled.

Yet he nor I would like them be in vice,
While by their *play-things*, I would them entice,
To mount their thoughts from what are childish toys,
To Heav'n, for that's prepar'd for girls and boys.
Nor do I so confine my self to these,
As to shun graver things, I seek to please,
Those more compos'd with better things than toys:
Tho' thus I would be catching girls and boys.

Wherefore if men have now a mind to look;
Perhaps their greater fancies may be took
With what is here; though but in homely rhimes:
But he, who pleases all, must rise betimes.
Some, I perswade me, will be finding fault,
Concluding, here I trip, and there I halt,
No doubt some could these groveling notions raise
By fine-spun terms that challenge might the bays.²
But should all men be forc't to lay aside
Their brains, that cannot regulate the tide:
By this or that man's fancy, we should have
The wise, unto the fool, become a slave.
What tho' my text seems mean, my morals be
Grave, as if fetcht from a sublimer tree.
And if some better handle can a fly,

²The bays: A reference to the laurel wreath (bay leaves) traditionally worn by poets and conquerors as a symbol of honor and literary achievement.

Then some a text, why should we them deny
Their making proof, or good experiment,
Of smallest things great mischiefs to prevent?

Wise Solomon did fools to piss-ants³ send,
To learn true wisdom, and their lives to mend.
Yea, God by swallows, cuckows, and the ass;
Shews they are fools who let that season pass,
Which he put in their hand, that to obtain
Which is both present, and eternal gain.

I think the wiser sort my rhimes may slight
But what were I! The foolish will delight
To read them, and the foolish, God has chose.
And doth by foolish things, their minds compose,
And settle upon that which is divine:
Great things, by little ones, are made to shine.

I could, were I so pleas'd, use higher strains.
And for applause, on tenters stretch my brains,
But what needs that? The arrow out of sight,
Does not the sleeper, nor the watchman fright.
To shoot too high doth but make children gaze;
'Tis that which hits the man, doth him amaze.

³Piss-ants: An archaic term for common wood ants (also called pismires), named for the sharp, pungent scent of formic acid they produce.

And for the inconsiderableness
Of things, by which I do my mind express;
May I by them bring some good thing to pass,
As Sampson, with the jaw-bone of an ass;
Or as brave Shamgar with his oxen's goad,
(Both things not manly, nor for war in mode)
I have my end, tho' I my self expose
To scorn; God will have glory in the close.

Thus much for artificial babes; and now
To those who are in years but such, I bow
My pen to teach them what the letters be,
And how they may improve their A, B, C.
Nor let my pretty children them despise;
All needs must there begin, that would be wise.

Nor let *them* fall under discouragement,
Who at their hornbook stick,⁴ and time hath spent
Upon that A, B, C while others do
Into their primer, or their Psalter go.
Some boys with difficulty do begin,
Who in the end, the bays, and laurel win.

– J. B.

⁴Hornbook stick: A primary educational tool consisting of a wooden paddle covered by a translucent sheet of animal horn to protect the printed lesson. It represents the most basic level of instruction.

A Book for Boys and Girls

I

Upon the Ten Commandments

1. Thou shalt not have another God than me:
2. Thou shalt not to an image bow thy knee,
3. Thou shalt not take the Name of God in vain:
4. See that the Sabbath thou do not profain.
5. Honour thy father and thy mother too:
6. In act or thought see thou no murder do.
7. From fornication keep thy body clean:
8. Thou shalt not steal, though thou be very mean.⁵
9. Bear no false witness, keep thee without spot:
10. What is thy neighbour's see thou covet not.

II

The Awakened Child's Lamentation

When Adam was deceived,
I was of life bereaved;

⁵Mean: Poor or impoverished.

Of late (too) I perceived,
I was in sin conceived.

And as I was born naked,
I was with filth bespaked,⁶
At which when I awaked,
My soul and spirit shaken.

My filth grew strong, and boyled,
And me throughout defiled,
My pleasures me beguiled,
My soul! how art thou spoyled!

My joys with sin were painted,
My mind with sin is tainted,
My heart with guilt is fainted,
I wa'nt with God acquainted.

I have in sin abounded,
My heart therewith is wounded,
With fears I am surrounded,
My spirit is confounded.

I have been often called,
By sin as oft enthralled,
Pleasures hath me fore-stalled.
How is my spirit gauled!

⁶Bespaked: Marked or stained.

As sin has me infected,
I am thereof detected:
Mercy I have neglected,
I fear I am rejected.

The Word I have mis-used
Good council too refused;
Thus I my self abused;
How can I be excused?

When other children prayed,
That work I then delayed,
Ran up and down and played;
And thus from God have strayed.

Had I in God delighted,
And my wrong doings righted;
I had not thus been frightened,
Nor as I am benighted.

O! That God would be pleased,
T'wards me to be appeased;
And heal me thus diseased,
How should I then be eased!

But Truth I have despised,
My follies idolized,

Saints with reproach disguised,
Salvation nothing prized.

O Lord! I am ashamed,
When I do hear thee named;
'Cause thee I have defamed,
And liv'd like beasts untamed!

Would God I might be saved,
Might have an heart like David;
This I have sometimes craved,
Yet am by sin enslaved!

Vanity I have loved,
My heart from God removed;
And not, as me behoved,
The means of grace improved.

O Lord! if I had cried
(When I told tales and lyed)
For mercy, and denied
My lusts, I had not died!

But Mercies-Gate is locked,
Yea, up that way is blocked;
Yea some that there have knocked,
God at their cries hath mocked.

‘Cause him they had disdained,
Their wicked ways maintained,
From godliness restrained,
And on his word complained.

I would I were converted
Would sin and I were parted,
For folly I have smarted;
God make me honest-hearted!

I have to grace appealed,
Would ‘twere to me revealed,
And pardon to me sealed,
Then should I soon be healed!

Whose nature God hath mended,
Whose sinful course is ended,
Who is to life ascended,
Of God is much befriended.

Oh! Were I reconciled
To God, I, tho’ defiled,
Should be as one that smiled,
To think my death was spoiled.

Lord! thou wast crucified
For sinners, bled and dyed,

I have for mercy cried,
Let me not be denied.

I have thy Spirit grieved;
Yet is my life reprieved,
Would I in thee believed,
Then I should be relieved.

Were but repentance gained,
And had I faith unfeigned,
Then joy would be maintained
In me, and sin restrained.

But this is to be noted,
I have on folly doted,
My vanities promoted,
My self to them devoted.

Thus I have sin committed,
And so my self out-witted;
Yea, and my soul unfitted,
To be to Heaven admitted.

But God has condescended,
And pardon has extended,
To such as have offended,
Before their lives were ended.

O Lord! do not disdain me,
But kindly entertain me;
Yea in thy faith maintain me,
And let thy love constrain me!

III

Meditations Upon An Egg

The egg's no chick by falling from the hen;
Nor man a Christian, till he's born agen.
The egg's at first contained in the shell;
Men afore grace, in sins, and darkness dwell.
The egg when laid, by warmth is made a chicken;
And Christ, by grace, those dead in sin doth
quicken.
The egg, when first a chick, the shell's its prison;
So's flesh to th' soul, who yet with Christ is risen.
The shell doth crack, the chick doth chirp and peep;
The flesh decays, as men do pray and weep.
The shell doth break, the chick's at liberty;
The flesh falls off, the soul mounts up on high.
But both do not enjoy the self-same plight;
The soul is safe, the chick now fears the kite.⁷

⁷Kite: A bird of prey.